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ecutive order, these personnel were absorbed into the regular force after five years, provided they completed the mandated training. However, in 2013, the then DGP, Nandan Dubey, put an end to this practice, citing the promotion avenues available to the constable tradesmen within their own cadre. In 2019, a few who moved the high court did get absorbed into the regular force in Mandsaur district, but, as a policy, such recruitments have been stopped for the past one decade—so much so that interventions made by their political bosses have also failed to budge the strong IPS lobby. State home minister Narottam Mishra had in March 2022 written to the state police department,

MP'S IPS OFFICERS RESIST GIVING UP ON THEIR BATTERY OF DOMESTIC HELPS DRAWN FROM LOWER RUNGS OF THE FORCE



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

asking for the promotion process to be resumed. Even the finance department in 2019 clarified that absorbing constable tradesmen into the regular police force would not impose any additional financial burden.

Some of the affected constables, who talked to INDIA TODAY on the condition of anonymity, claim they are being denied their "right" so that the senior officers can have enough personnel to work in their homes. However, a senior officer points to conflicting instances where constables recently withdrawn from domestic duties requested to be reinstated on the same job, given the "lighter" workload.

"I cannot comment on the matter, but any injustice would be corrected if pointed out," is all what Sajid Farid Shapoo, the additional director general, SAF, has to say on the issue. Another senior officer at the police headquarters maintains that "the option of being absorbed as general duty constables cannot be claimed as a right", as it was provided in 1993 "considering certain issues at that time" and was later withdrawn. Insisting that the "two issues need to be delinked", he, however, admits that "nothing justifies armies of helps working at homes of senior officers". That said, the issue at hand also has wider implications for the state's finances. The All India Services officers are known to have a battery of domestic helps. However, unlike their IAS and forest service counterparts, IPS officers mostly have constables, head constables and in some cases even assistant sub-inspectors (ASIs) at their disposal instead of 'cheaper' outsourced staff.

Consequently, these 'home services' are running up huge tabs. For instance, a constable draws a salary of about Rs 25,000 per month. In the case of an ASI, it's as high as Rs 70,000. Most of them are performing tasks like gardening, cooking or cleaning, for which outsourced staff can be engaged for monthly wages as low as Rs 10,000. A switch will not only preserve the sanctity of the uniform but also free up the constable tradesmen to be absorbed into the regular force, thus making additional personnel available for core policing. But will the IPS lobby budge? ■